
Cut down your infrastructure

My friend Ray first showed me how silly it is to complicate our lives with more infrastructure than we need. Ray seemed to prefer sitting in the quad and watching people go by than studying to get ahead. He went to every party he heard about and drank beer in industrial quantities. He chose graduate school in electronics not to prepare for a fast-track career but because it intrigued him. His first job was at in electronics in Phoenix. Soon he was earning good money, and he and his wife decided to buy a house.

"Before we went to see the realtor," Ray told me at the time, "we wrote down what we wanted. We agreed on a formal living room, separate dining room. That meant we needed a family room for informal parties and TV football games. And it's nice to have a separate den with a desk, away from the TV. We planned to wait several years before having kids, but for resale value we decided on three or four bedrooms. We wanted a large master bedroom suite to have a comfortable, private place to sit and read. We had a puppy, so of course we needed a big yard. And so on."

Ray laughed and shook his head. "It was crazy. We didn't need *any* of that stuff. The next day we went out and bought a two-bedroom, 950-square-foot house a few miles from the office."

Ray's good judgment prevailed when he was 23. But by the time he was 35 he had moved to a house the size of the Grand Canyon. He had a maid, three refrigerators, two freezers, six phones, two VCRs, and five TVs. What happened to Ray's good judgment?

A couple of kids changed things a bit. A larger family requires more space. But even without kids, as we get older I think we tend to buy more freely, get used to household machines, and convince ourselves that luxuries are necessities. We're not always sure we like or need the more complicated life. Maybe that's why camping—living with next to